Rurality transitions compress the measured nonmetro–metro Republican vote gap

County-level presidential patterns, 1960–2020

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Abstract

Where Americans live increasingly lines up with how they vote, with consequences for representation and policy. Brown and Mettler (2025) and Brown and Mettler (2024) document a widening county-level divide in presidential elections after decades of relative similarity. This paper asks a measurement question that sits alongside that story: when the Census and USDA reclassify growing counties from nonmetro to metro, those counties are often politically in-between "stayers," so the usual *time-varying* metro/nonmetro comparison can understate how separated nonmetro places are from long-run metro places. Using county presidential returns (1960–2020) and USDA Rural–Urban Continuum Codes, I show that the vote-weighted nonmetro–metro gap grows sharply from the 1990s onward and that alternative ways of grouping counties—especially excluding recent "urbanizers" from the metro side—produce a materially larger gap in levels. The analysis combines descriptive trends, a Kitagawa–Oaxaca–Blinder decomposition of changes in the gap, and weighted regressions with state-clustered standard errors. Findings are descriptive, not causal: the paper clarifies how much reported polarization depends on moving administrative lines, not only on changing votes.

1 Introduction

How voting lines up with official metro and nonmetro geography is central to diagnosing spatial polarization and the health of U.S. democracy. Institutions such as the Senate and the Electoral College amplify less populous areas; when partisan preferences increasingly align with place, small shifts in where votes are cast can change who governs (Rodden 2019). Brown and Mettler (2025) place a rural–urban cleavage at the center of contemporary democratic stress, and Brown and Mettler (2024) show county-level presidential votes moving together through the 1980s before diverging sharply in the 1990s. This paper uses USDA Rural–Urban Continuum Codes (RUCC), not literal "urban cores": the metro side of the contrast pools suburban and exurban counties with principal cities. The substantive point is that the nonmetro–metro gap in Republican vote share can *look smaller* when the classification is updated every year than when one compares nonmetro counties to places that stay metro in the long run, because counties reclassified from nonmetro to metro are often politically intermediate.

Through the mid-century, nonmetro and metro counties often moved together in presidential elections; sustained divergence gathers force from the 1990s onward, as counties under economic stress or population loss drift Republican while growing metropolitan areas trend Democratic (Brown and Mettler 2024). The descriptive plots below match that timing. The open question is whether the usual *time-varying* rural/non-rural split understates how far apart nonmetro and long-run metro places have become, because growing

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During the preparation of this work I used Cursor 2.6.22 in order to assist in code editing, text edits, and reference management. After using this tool/service, I reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the paper.

counties are reclassified out of the nonmetro category at the same time as they sit between rural stayers and stable metro places in partisanship.

Brown and Mettler (2025) develop the book-length argument behind themes readers may know from the sequential article on polarization (Brown and Mettler 2024). *Rural Versus Urban* treats the rural–urban cleavage as a central dimension of contemporary American conflict and traces economic restructuring, cultural mobilization, and party–elite disconnect. The account is also institutional: where votes live can translate into durable advantages in Congress, the presidency, and courts. The empirical work here is a **measurement** complement to that narrative. I show that county-level vote-weighted series and election-span decompositions line up with the post-1990 acceleration in Brown and Mettler (2024): much of the widening gap arrives in short windows such as 1992–2000 and 2008–2016 rather than as a smooth linear drift from 1960. A Kitagawa–Oaxaca–Blinder decomposition (Kitagawa 1955; Oaxaca 1973; Blinder 1973) separates **reclassification** of official nonmetro status from **within-county** changes in Republican share and from **shifts in vote weights** across counties—so readers can see whether the growing divide reflects changing votes holding early classification fixed, or movement of intermediate counties across the USDA boundary. **Urbanizer** and baseline-locked counterfactuals show how sensitive the time-varying metro average is to counties that exit the nonmetro category. Finally, I use both a year-specific nonmetro indicator and five long-run transition categories (remained nonmetro, remained metro, changers, mixed) so that fixed versus moving labels are explicit.

Public debate often treats "rural" and "urban" as fixed identities, but official boundaries move when commuting patterns and populations change. Johnson and Scala (2022) argue for a continuum of place types rather than a blunt binary. Qualitative work by Cramer (2016) emphasizes rural consciousness and perceived disrespect from urban elites—mechanisms that county aggregates cannot recover. Here the object of interest is administrative geography: RUCC captures position within metro and commuting systems, not residents' subjective rural identity. Counties that remain metro over the long run hold a large share of national two-party votes; consistently nonmetro counties cast fewer votes but cover most land area; counties that transition from nonmetro to metro sit in between. The empirical sections report vote-weighted trends in Republican share by transition category and the time-varying nonmetro–metro gap; decompositions of the national gap and of shorter election spans; weighted least squares with remained nonmetro omitted and state-clustered standard errors; and contrasts among time-varying status, baseline-locked definitions, and an urbanizer counterfactual for the metro mean. The analysis is **descriptive**: transition categories and RUCC status are joint outcomes of economics, demography, and politics, not exogenous treatments. The decomposition answers an accounting question about how much of the changing gap lines up with reclassification versus vote and weight shifts.

2 Data and measurement

The analysis file is a county–year panel of presidential returns from 1960 to 2020 merged with USDA RUCC. County-level presidential returns are harmonised to two-party Republican vote share and two-party vote totals; county–years with zero two-party votes are excluded from weighted statistics. Gubernatorial rows remain in the merged panel for other uses but are excluded from the figures and tables here. Build steps appear in the Replication section.

Nonmetro status is **time-varying**: a county–year is nonmetro (rural) if RUCC indicates non-metropolitan status (RUCC ≥ 4); otherwise it is metro (non-rural). "Non-rural" thus includes suburban and exurban metro counties, not only dense urban cores. USDA materials arrive as vintages; each election year is matched to a county–year classification row (the data appendix documents snapshots, carry-back for pre-1970 years, and dropped unmatched rows). County–years with no RUCC match after harmonisation are dropped.

Each county is also assigned to one of five **transition categories** from the path of the harmonized rural indicator between 1960 and 2020: remained rural, remained non-rural, changed to non-rural, changed to rural, or mixed. Because the early panel includes pre-first-observation carry-back years, these categories summarize long-run coding trajectories rather than only directly observed USDA transitions. State abbreviations map to census region (four regions) for heterogeneity tables.

County–year statistics and regressions weight observations by two-party vote totals, so the estimand is

the voting population (ballots), not geographic area or equal weight per county. That matches the goal of describing national election outcomes; it differs from institutional arguments that weight land or states. Unweighted OLS for the same specification (state-clustered SEs) is reported in Section 7.

3 Methods

3.1 Three estimands (levels, changes, and 2020 contrasts)

The paper reports three descriptive objects. First, **levels and trends**: vote-weighted nonmetro–metro gaps G_t and Republican means by transition category under the time-varying RUCC indicator. Second, **changes in the gap** on a county overlap sample: let $G_t = \bar{y}_t^r - \bar{y}_t^{nr}$ be the vote-weighted nonmetro minus metro Republican share gap in year t. Define $\Delta G = G_T - G_0$ as the change in that gap between a start election $t = 0$ and an end election T (often 2020). The decomposition below applies to this ΔG, not to every statistic in the paper. Third, **level comparisons** in 2020 under alternative definitions—e.g. time-varying metro pooling versus excluding "urbanizers" from the metro mean—which measure how grouping rules affect the *static* gap; that third object is distinct from ΔG on 1960–2020. The abstract's illustration comparing about 0.240 to 0.215 belongs to this third family; the decomposition tables target the second.

3.2 Descriptive trends and gaps

Let y_{it} denote two-party Republican share for county i in election year t, and w_{it} two-party votes. For any subgroup S of county–years, the vote-weighted mean is $\sum_{(i,t)\in S} w_{it} y_{it} / \sum_{(i,t)\in S} w_{it}$. I plot weighted means by transition category and year and the gap between counties classified nonmetro versus metro in year t using the **time-varying** indicator.

3.3 Kitagawa / Oaxaca–Blinder decomposition

Let R_{it} indicate nonmetro status. Write vote-weighted nonmetro and metro means and the gap $G_t = \bar{y}_t^r - \bar{y}_t^{nr}$. For endpoints $t = 0$ and T, $\Delta G = G_T - G_0$ is decomposed using the **first standard sequential path** in the Kitagawa–Oaxaca–Blinder literature: (i) a **composition** term that captures how much ΔG is due to updating official nonmetro status while holding terminal vote weights and outcomes in a particular order; (ii) a **vote-weight shift** term that reallocates votes across counties holding early nonmetro status fixed and using terminal Republican shares in a middle step; and (iii) a **within-share** term that captures changes in Republican share within counties holding early nonmetro status and early weights fixed. The three terms sum exactly to ΔG. For national and regional tables, the decomposition uses the **overlap sample** of counties present in both endpoint years with valid votes and shares—the change in the gap for a stable county set. A post-1974 sensitivity restricts the panel to years at or after 1974. Senate Kitagawa rows are in Section 6.

The same decomposition is repeated for shorter **election-span** windows between presidential years (1960–1968 through 2016–2020). For each window from year a to year b, $\Delta G = G_b - G_a$ denotes the change in the nonmetro–metro gap over that span using the same overlap logic within the span. Because the descriptive gap widens most sharply after roughly the 1990s, sub-period rows highlight where within-share change and vote-weight reallocation are largest. A post-1974 variant drops spans whose start year is before 1974.

3.4 Weighted regression

The main regression summary uses the following WLS specification:

$$\text{rep_share}_{it} = \alpha + \beta \tilde{t} + \sum_k \gamma_k \mathbf{1}\{\text{cat}_i = k\} + \sum_k \delta_k \tilde{t} \times \mathbf{1}\{\text{cat}_i = k\} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where $\tilde{t}$ is election year minus the sample mean year and the omitted category is remained rural. Standard errors are clustered by state. Additional estimates appear in the technical companion report.

3.5 Urbanizers and baseline-locked rural status

I contrast three series: the time-varying nonmetro minus metro gap; the baseline-locked gap (nonmetro if nonmetro in baseline year b); and a counterfactual that compares time-varying nonmetro counties to stable-metro counties only, excluding counties that were nonmetro at b but metro at t ("urbanizers") from the metro mean. Baseline year b is typically 1960 presidential in the figures; because early years use carried-back RUCC, contrasts that lean on the 1960s should be checked against baselines that use only observed vintages (e.g. 1974 onward)—see discussion.

3.6 Within-decade contrasts

As a complement to linear trends, I report within-decade differences between category-specific weighted means and the remained rural mean in the same decade (technical companion).

4 Results

4.1 Trends and the nonmetro–metro gap

Figure 1 introduces the descriptive patterns. Panel (a) plots vote-weighted two-party Republican share separately for counties classified **nonmetro** and **metro** in each election year (time-varying RUCC), so readers see levels before the gap. Panel (b) is the same construction as the prior single-panel "trends" figure: Republican means by long-run transition category. Figure 2 then plots the **nonmetro minus metro** gap implied by panel (a)—about 0.036 in 1992 and about 0.215 in 2020, the roughly five-fold increase highlighted in the abstract. Together, the figures make the timing of divergence visible before turning to accounting decompositions.

Senate versions of the Figure 1 panel and the gap series use the same construction; they appear in Section 6.

4.2 Decomposition

Figure 3 summarizes the three decomposition components for the main and post-1974 specifications. In the main overlap sample, the nonmetro–metro gap rises from about 0.060 in 1960 to about 0.215 in 2020, a total increase of about 0.155. The **composition** piece (reclassification holding terminal weights and outcomes in the Kitagawa ordering) is about 0.011; the **vote-weight shift** piece is about −0.070; the **within-share** piece is about 0.215. Long-run widening is therefore not driven solely by the composition term.

Table 1: Decomposition of change in rural—non-rural Republican share gap (presidential)

Office	Spec.	Start	End	N	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Presidential	Main	1960	2020	3,095	0.155	0.011	-0.070	0.215
Presidential	Post-1974	1976	2020	3,107	0.221	0.010	-0.040	0.251

Notes: All entries are share points. Composition holds terminal vote weights and outcomes fixed; see text. Post-1974 uses years ≥ 1974; presidential starts in 1976 under this rule (election years).

4.3 Decomposition by election span

For each election span from year a to year b, recall that $\Delta G = G_b - G_a$ is the change in the nonmetro–metro gap over that interval on the overlap sample. Figure 4 plots the three decomposition components for each span in the main presidential sample. The 1992–2000 and 2008–2016 intervals stand out for large positive ΔG and large within-share contributions, consistent with intensification of the divide after the early 1990s rather than smooth drift from 1960.

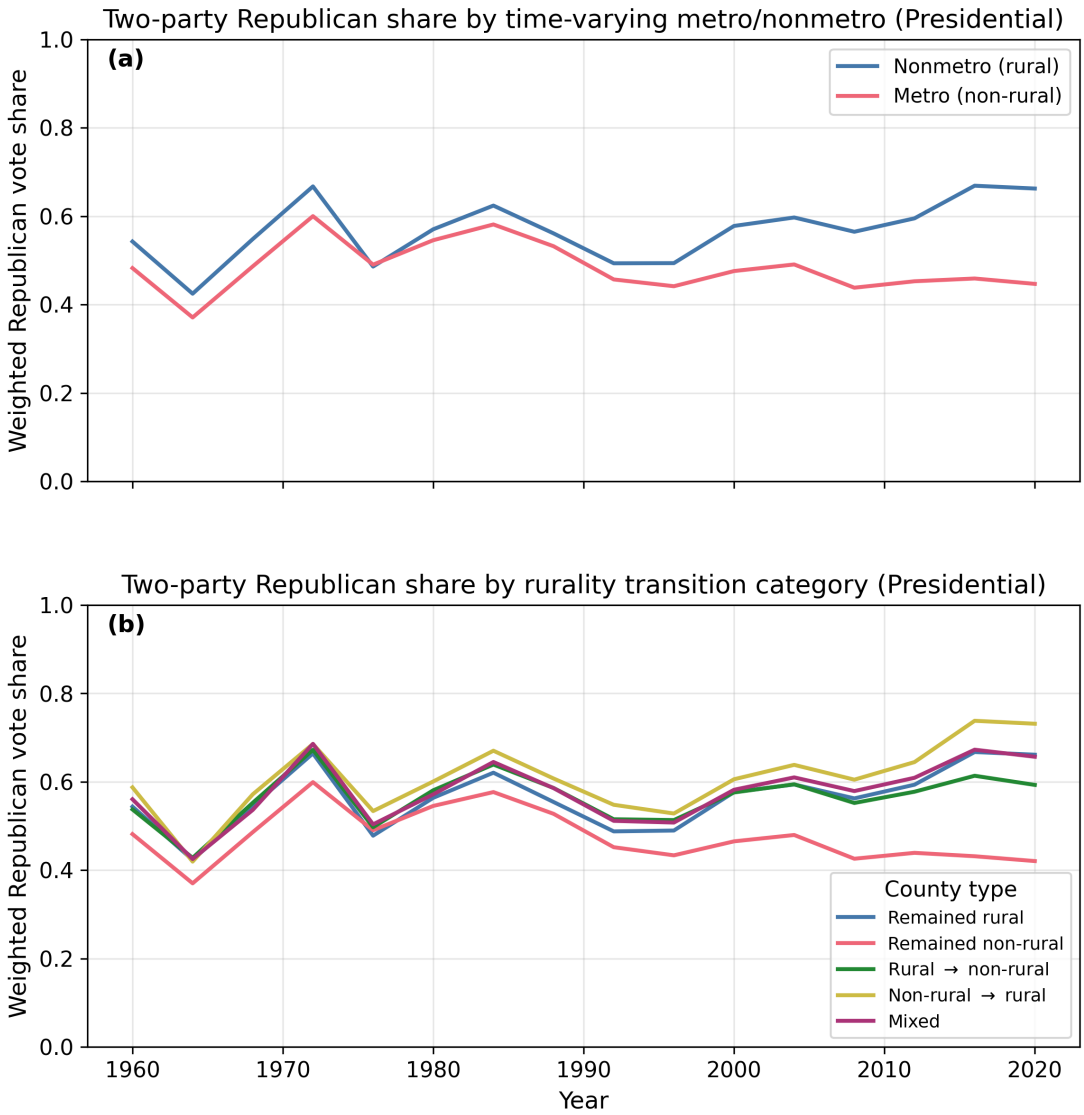

Figure 1: (a) Vote-weighted Republican share by time-varying metro/nonmetro (RUCC). (b) Vote-weighted means by long-run transition category.

Table 2: Decomposition by election span (main sample)

Office	Period	N	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Presidential	1960–1968	3,099	0.001	0.000	-0.012	0.013
Presidential	1972–1980	3,109	-0.043	0.000	-0.012	-0.030
Presidential	1980–1992	3,112	0.012	-0.010	-0.005	0.027
Presidential	1992–2000	3,113	0.065	-0.003	-0.007	0.075
Presidential	2000–2008	3,113	0.025	0.000	-0.005	0.029
Presidential	2008–2016	3,112	0.083	-0.002	0.001	0.085
Presidential	2016–2020	3,113	0.006	0.000	-0.003	0.009

Notes: Each row decomposes the change in the vote-weighted rural—non-rural Republican share gap between the listed presidential election years (inclusive endpoints). Units: share points. See text for definitions of the three components.

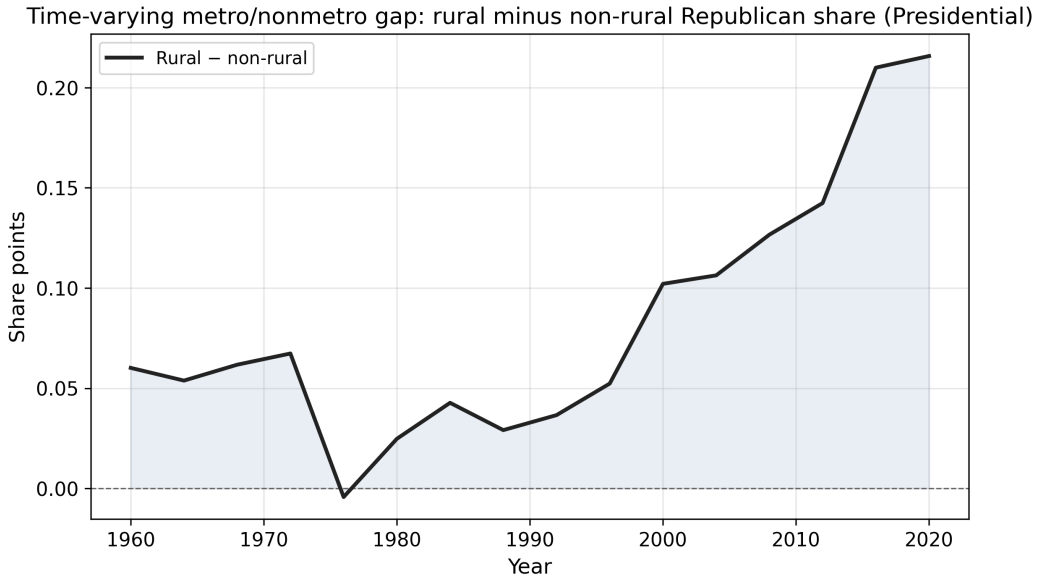

Figure 2: Vote-weighted nonmetro minus metro Republican share (time-varying classification).

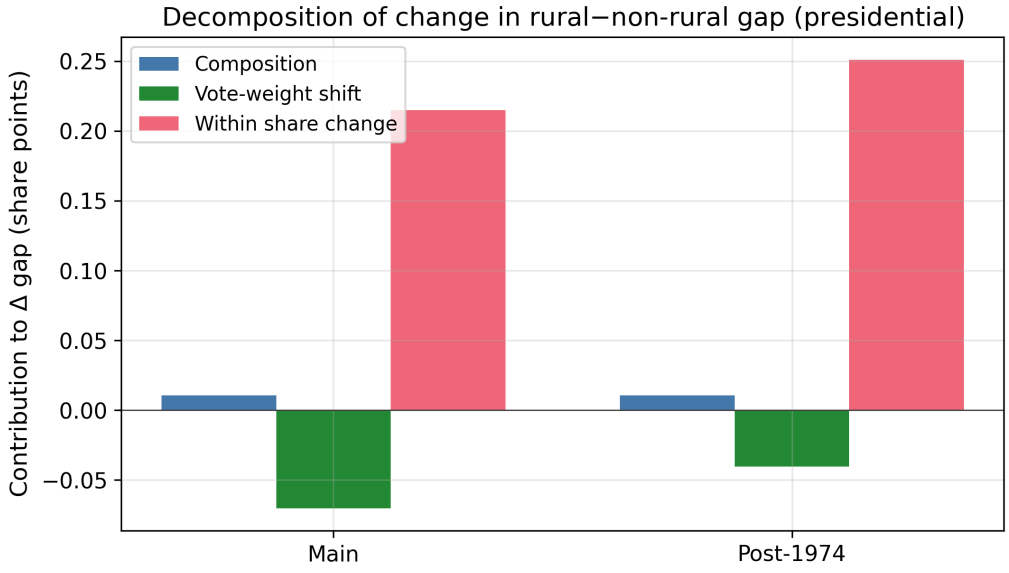

Figure 3: Decomposition of the change in the gap: composition, vote-weight shift, and within-share change.

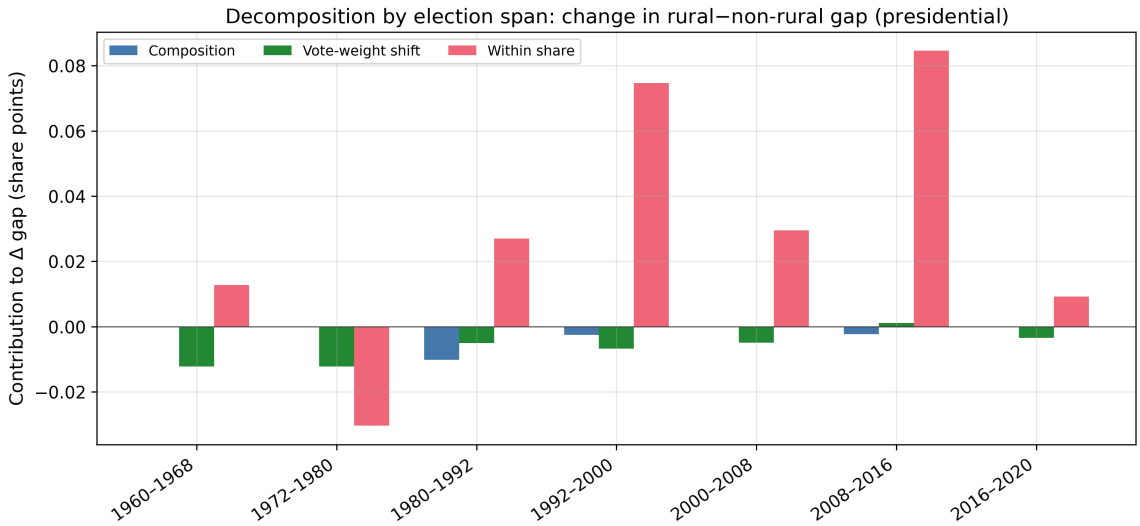

Figure 4: Decomposition by election span: change in the gap and components for each listed window.

4.4 Baseline-locked gap and urbanizers

Figure 5 and Figure 6 contrast time-varying, baseline-locked, and stable-metro counterfactuals. In 2020, the standard time-varying gap is about 0.215, while the comparison that pools only *stable* metro counties on the metro side is about 0.240. The time-varying gap is thus about 11 percent smaller than that stable-metro comparison when counties that urbanize are included in the metro mean.

4.5 Regression (national)

The next table reports national WLS with transition-category dummies (remained rural omitted) and a common linear time trend. Coefficients summarize gaps relative to rural stayers. Senate estimates appear in Section 6.

Table 3: Weighted least squares: Republican share on year and rurality categories (presidential)

	Coef.	SE
Intercept	0.5654***	(0.0065)
Rural to non-rural	-0.0002	(0.0066)
Non-rural to rural	0.0433***	(0.0132)
Mixed	0.0135	(0.0100)
Remained non-rural	-0.0880***	(0.0107)
Year (centered)	0.0020***	(0.0003)
Year (centered) x Rural to non-rural	-0.0010***	(0.0003)
Year (centered) x Non-rural to rural	0.0006	(0.0006)
Year (centered) x Mixed	-0.0001	(0.0005)
Year (centered) x Remained non-rural	-0.0034***	(0.0004)

Notes: WLS weights are two-party votes. Standard errors clustered by state. Omitted category: remained rural. $N = 49,783$, states=50, $R^2 = 0.141$. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

4.6 Category effects by decade (WLS)

The national specification imposes one linear time trend for all counties with category-specific intercepts and slopes. To summarize level gaps relative to remained rural without that restriction, the same category-dummy specification is fit **separately within each decade bucket**. The decade table reinforces the compression story: changed-to-nonrural counties sit modestly above remained-rural counties in the 1990s but below

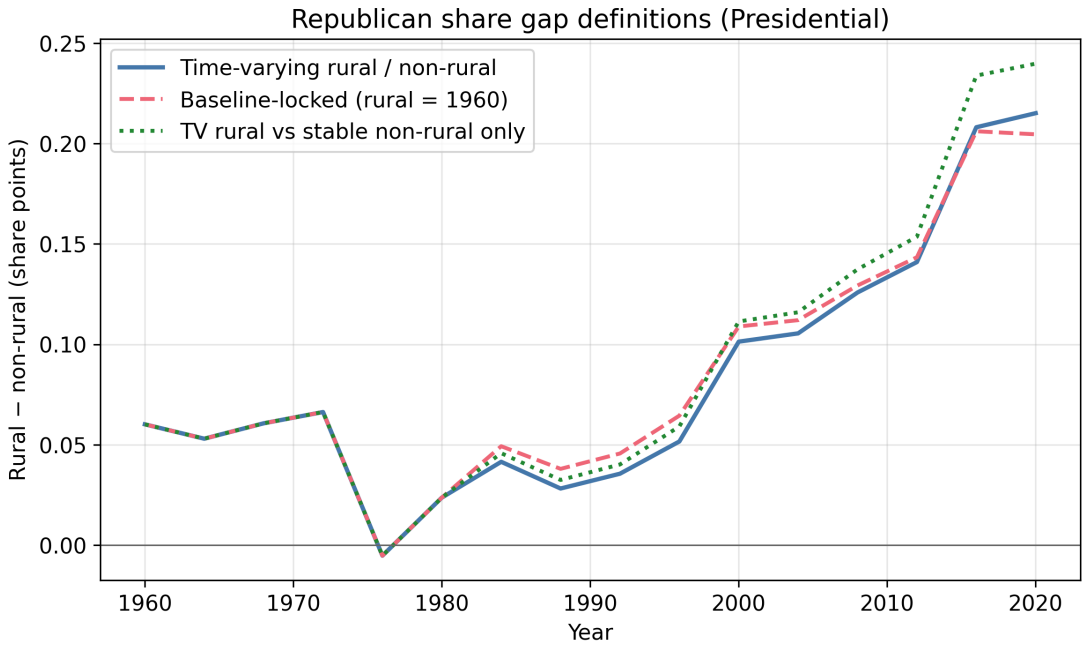

Figure 5: Three definitions of the nonmetro minus metro gap.

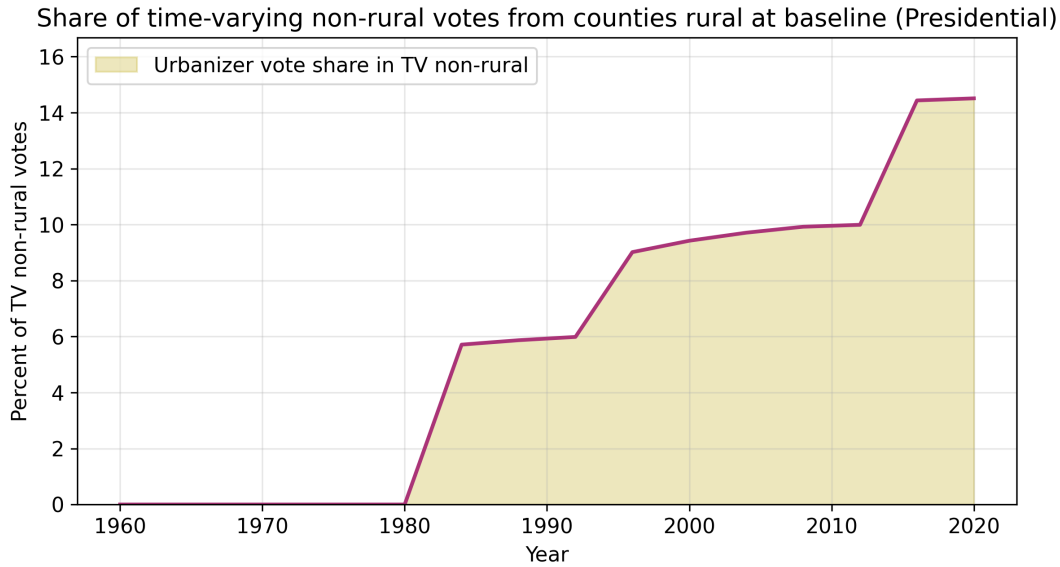

Figure 6: Share of metro votes from urbanizers (nonmetro at baseline, metro in the current year).

them in the 2020 column (single election), while remained-nonrural counties remain far more Democratic throughout.

Table 4: WLS category effects by decade bucket (separate regression per decade; no year trend)

	Pre-1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020
Remained rural (intercept)	0.5300*** (0.0075)	0.5805*** (0.0077)	0.4889*** (0.0078)	0.5777*** (0.0103)	0.6302*** (0.0136)	0.6614*** (0.0145)
Remained non-rural (vs. rem. rural)	-0.0421*** (0.0121)	-0.0302** (0.0117)	-0.0461*** (0.0127)	-0.1220*** (0.0126)	-0.1948*** (0.0162)	-0.2407*** (0.0156)
Rural to non-rural (vs. rem. rural)	0.0084 (0.0070)	0.0226** (0.0092)	0.0255*** (0.0082)	-0.0044 (0.0077)	-0.0343*** (0.0100)	-0.0684*** (0.0112)
Non-rural to rural (vs. rem. rural)	0.0296** (0.0133)	0.0467*** (0.0174)	0.0491*** (0.0163)	0.0392** (0.0190)	0.0611** (0.0248)	0.0700*** (0.0241)
Mixed (vs. rem. rural)	0.0130 (0.0118)	0.0216* (0.0127)	0.0209 (0.0132)	0.0129 (0.0147)	0.0110 (0.0200)	-0.0046 (0.0212)

Notes: Each column is a **separate** WLS fit on county–years in that decade bucket only; specification is rep_share on transition-category dummies with *remained rural* omitted. Weights: two-party votes; standard errors clustered by state. Coefficients on categories are gaps vs. remained rural in that decade (share units). Intercept row is the fitted level for remained rural. The **2020** column uses the 2020 presidential election only (not a full ten-year decade). $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

4.7 Baseline 1960–1988 and election × category interactions

A further expansion pools 1960–1988 as a single omitted time block (all county–years with election year 1988) and again omits remained rural. The model is vote-weighted WLS with state-clustered standard errors and a full interaction between election year and transition category: every post-1988 election in the panel enters as its own factor level interacted with category. The baseline column of the tables reports the 1960–1988 category coefficient (the gap vs. remained rural in that pooled baseline period). Later columns are interaction terms: how much that gap changes relative to 1960–1988 at the listed election.

The same 1960–1988 / post-1988 election structure is repeated using the time-varying rural indicator from `rural_flag`, with rural omitted. Those companion tables have two rows per office. The rural row reports the fitted rural level in the baseline column and the change in that fitted level at each later election. The non-rural row reports the 1960–1988 non-rural minus rural gap in the baseline column and, in later columns, the change in that gap relative to the 1960–1988 baseline.

Table 5: Presidential: baseline gaps (1960–1988) and change in gap vs. that baseline by election (*remained rural* omitted). $N = 49,783$, states=50, $R^2 = 0.180$.

Category	1960–1988 gap	1992	1996	2000	2004	2008	2012	2016	2020
Remained non-rural	-0.0369*** (0.0120)	0.0010 (0.0089)	-0.0193** (0.0083)	-0.0746*** (0.0110)	-0.0774*** (0.0107)	-0.0997*** (0.0154)	-0.1174*** (0.0166)	-0.1990*** (0.0197)	-0.2039*** (0.0183)
Rural to non-rural	0.0171** (0.0080)	0.0103** (0.0042)	0.0066 (0.0062)	-0.0179** (0.0082)	-0.0167* (0.0089)	-0.0275** (0.0108)	-0.0330*** (0.0114)	-0.0708*** (0.0113)	-0.0855*** (0.0124)
Non-rural to rural	0.0355** (0.0142)	0.0247** (0.0111)	0.0030 (0.0146)	-0.0064 (0.0147)	0.0089 (0.0202)	0.0069 (0.0291)	0.0156 (0.0301)	0.0352 (0.0263)	0.0345 (0.0266)
Mixed	0.0174 (0.0119)	0.0064 (0.0083)	0.0006 (0.0085)	-0.0121 (0.0108)	-0.0014 (0.0150)	-0.0009 (0.0219)	-0.0018 (0.0232)	-0.0121 (0.0255)	-0.0221 (0.0262)

Notes: Vote-weighted WLS; SEs clustered by state. **1960–1988 gap** is the category coefficient in the baseline period (vs. *remained rural*). Later columns are **interaction** terms: change in that gap relative to 1960–1988 for the listed election. Share units (0–1). $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Table 6: Presidential: time-varying rural (omitted) vs. non-rural; 1960–1988 baseline and post-1988 election interactions. $N = 49,783$, states=50, $R^2 = 0.127$.

Row	1960–1988 base	1992	1996	2000	2004	2008	2012	2016	2020
Rural (level / Δ vs. 1960–1988)	0.5544*** (0.0062)	-0.0609*** (0.0057)	-0.0605*** (0.0075)	0.0237*** (0.0090)	0.0428*** (0.0107)	0.0105 (0.0144)	0.0409*** (0.0147)	0.1147*** (0.0142)	0.1083*** (0.0155)
Non-rural (vs. rural)	-0.0380*** (0.0109)	0.0014 (0.0086)	-0.0143** (0.0070)	-0.0641*** (0.0097)	-0.0683*** (0.0097)	-0.0886*** (0.0139)	-0.1044*** (0.0149)	-0.1720*** (0.0190)	-0.1778*** (0.0177)

Notes: Vote-weighted WLS; SEs clustered by state. **Rural** is the RUCC-based indicator in each county–year (RUCC ≥ 4); **rural** is omitted. **1960–1988 base:** rural row = intercept (fitted Republican share for rural county–years in the baseline period); non-rural row = non-rural minus rural in that baseline. **Later columns** on the rural row are **period mains** (change in rural fitted level vs. the baseline block at each election). On the non-rural row they are **interactions**: change in the non-rural minus rural gap relative to 1960–1988. Share units (0–1). $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

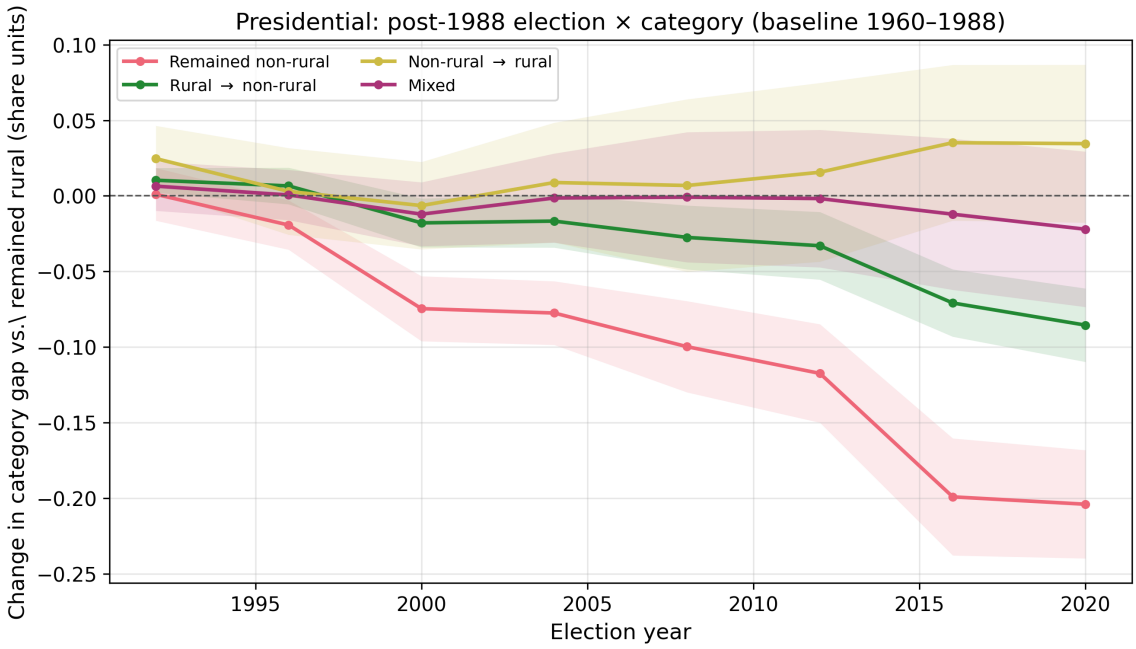

Figure 7: Estimated interaction terms (95% bands): change in category gap vs. remained rural after 1988.

4.8 Heterogeneity by census region

Decomposition by **census region** (Northeast, Midwest, South, West) uses the same inner-join logic as the national table: within each region, counties are kept only if they appear in both the start year and 2020 with positive two-party votes; nonmetro status at each date is the **time-varying** RUCC-based indicator. Stratifying by four regions rather than nine divisions yields larger subsamples and more stable regional contrasts.

Table 7: Kitagawa decomposition by census region (time-varying metro vs. nonmetro)

Region	N	Start	End	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Midwest	1,053	1960	2020	0.125	0.010	-0.057	0.172
Northeast	217	1960	2020	0.026	0.008	-0.050	0.067
South	1,411	1960	2020	0.239	0.006	-0.055	0.288
West	414	1960	2020	0.178	0.005	-0.079	0.252

Notes: Same decomposition structure as Table 1; here metro/nonmetro is the **time-varying** RUCC flag at start and end years (regional subsamples). Units: share points.

Regional WLS level effects (transition categories vs. remained rural) appear in the replication materials (`tab_06_wls_by_region.tex`).

5 Discussion

The empirical story has three layers that reinforce each other. First, Figure 1 and Figure 2 show *when* the nonmetro–metro divide widens: mid-century comovement, then a sustained break from the 1990s forward, matching the chronology emphasized by Brown and Mettler (2024). Second, the **national decomposition** separates how much of the long-run change in ΔG is tied to reclassification of official status versus within-county shifts in Republican share versus reallocation of vote weight across counties. The composition term is not zero—reclassification matters for measurement—but the within-share and vote-weight pieces dominate the long-run increase in the overlap sample, so the paper is not "only" a story about USDA labels. Third,

the **election-span** decompositions localize *when* those accounting pieces are largest: the 1992–2000 and 2008–2016 windows stand out, which lines up with a literature on sorting and polarization in those eras rather than a gradual century-long drift.

The **national WLS** table compresses the transition-category pattern into a single parametric summary: long-run nonmetro counties and changers sit at different distances from nonmetro stayers in levels and trends, paralleling the gap and trend figures. The **decade-stratified** fits relax the common linear time trend and show how gaps versus remained nonmetro evolve across eras—useful for readers who worry that a single slope for all counties is too stiff. The **post-1988 interaction** design and the **time-varying nonmetro (omitted) vs. metro** analogue trace how gaps move election-by-election after a 1960–1988 baseline; Figure 7 makes the category-level dynamics visible at a glance.

Urbanizers matter for interpreting the time-varying metro mean. Pooling counties that have recently left the nonmetro category raises the metro average Republican share and pulls the headline nonmetro–metro gap toward zero relative to a counterfactual that keeps only long-run metro counties on the metro side. That is a point about **grouping and descriptive estimands**, not a claim that urbanizers are the deep cause of national polarization. Read alongside Rodden (2019), the results caution that "how large is the rural–urban divide?" is not a single number—it depends on whether metro is defined as "whatever is officially metro this year" or "places that have been metro for the whole panel."

Regional heterogeneity (four census regions) shows that the national decomposition masks geographic variation: regional rows in the Kitagawa table differ in levels and in the mix of composition, vote-weight, and within-share terms, even though the overlap logic is unchanged. That is consistent with Johnson and Scala (2022)'s emphasis on heterogeneity along continua of place, aggregated here to coarse regions for power.

Observed-vintage baseline (robustness). Main figures fix "baseline-locked" nonmetro status using the first election at or after 1960 with rural and non-rural vote mass (1960 for presidential). Replication also runs the same TV vs. baseline-locked and urbanizer logic with baseline floor **1974**, so the locked rural flag uses the first eligible election at or after 1974 (1976 for presidential). In 2020 presidential data, the time-varying gap and the counterfactual gap that excludes urbanizers from the metro mean are virtually unchanged between the two baseline rules (e.g. time-varying gap ≈ 0.215 in both; stable-metro counterfactual ≈ 0.240 vs. ≈ 0.241). The urbanizer share of metro votes and the implied "compression" from pooling urbanizers move only in the third decimal. Details are in `output/tables/tv_vs_baseline_rural_gap_summary.csv` and Table A4 in the technical companion include.

5.1 Limitations

County aggregates cannot recover rural consciousness, resentment, or media exposure (Cramer 2016), and they do not identify causal effects of trade, religion, or candidate strategy. RUCC is an administrative scheme, not ethnography. The analysis does not recover intra-rural diversity by race or ethnicity; the "mixed" transition category is small. County-level coding cannot separate suburban, exurban, and intra-county change. Early-decade RUCC for some county–years relies on carry-back from the first observed vintage; the observed-vintage baseline robustness above and the Kitagawa post-1974 sensitivity directly address reliance on pre-1974 coding for **baseline-locked** and **decomposition** objects. Extensions include richer clustering, dynamic models with county random effects, and survey or microdata that link voters to place.

5.2 Conclusion

The nonmetro–metro partisan divide in county presidential data is large, growing, and **sensitive to how metro and nonmetro are defined**. The time-varying gap rises from roughly 0.036 in 1992 to about 0.215 in 2020; a comparison that holds the metro side to long-run metro places yields a 2020 gap near 0.240—roughly eleven percent larger. That does not mean reclassification mechanically creates polarization; it means that counties crossing from nonmetro to metro often sit between nonmetro stayers and long-run metro places, so absorbing them into the metro mean **compresses** the headline divide in standard summaries.

For descriptive work on geographic polarization, the choice between time-varying and stable place definitions is substantively consequential. This paper supplies transparent county-year accounting—trends, decompositions,

regressions, and counterfactuals—so readers can interpret magnitudes alongside the historical and institutional arguments in Brown and Mettler (2025) and related work.

6 Appendix A: Senate results

The main text is presidential. This appendix collects the same designs for Senate county–years: the Figure 1-style panel (levels by time-varying metro/nonmetro and by transition category), the rural–non-rural gap, national Kitagawa rows, election-span decompositions, decade-stratified WLS, national transition-category and time-varying-rural WLS, post-1988 interaction tables, and the two-panel post-1988 interaction figure (presidential + Senate).

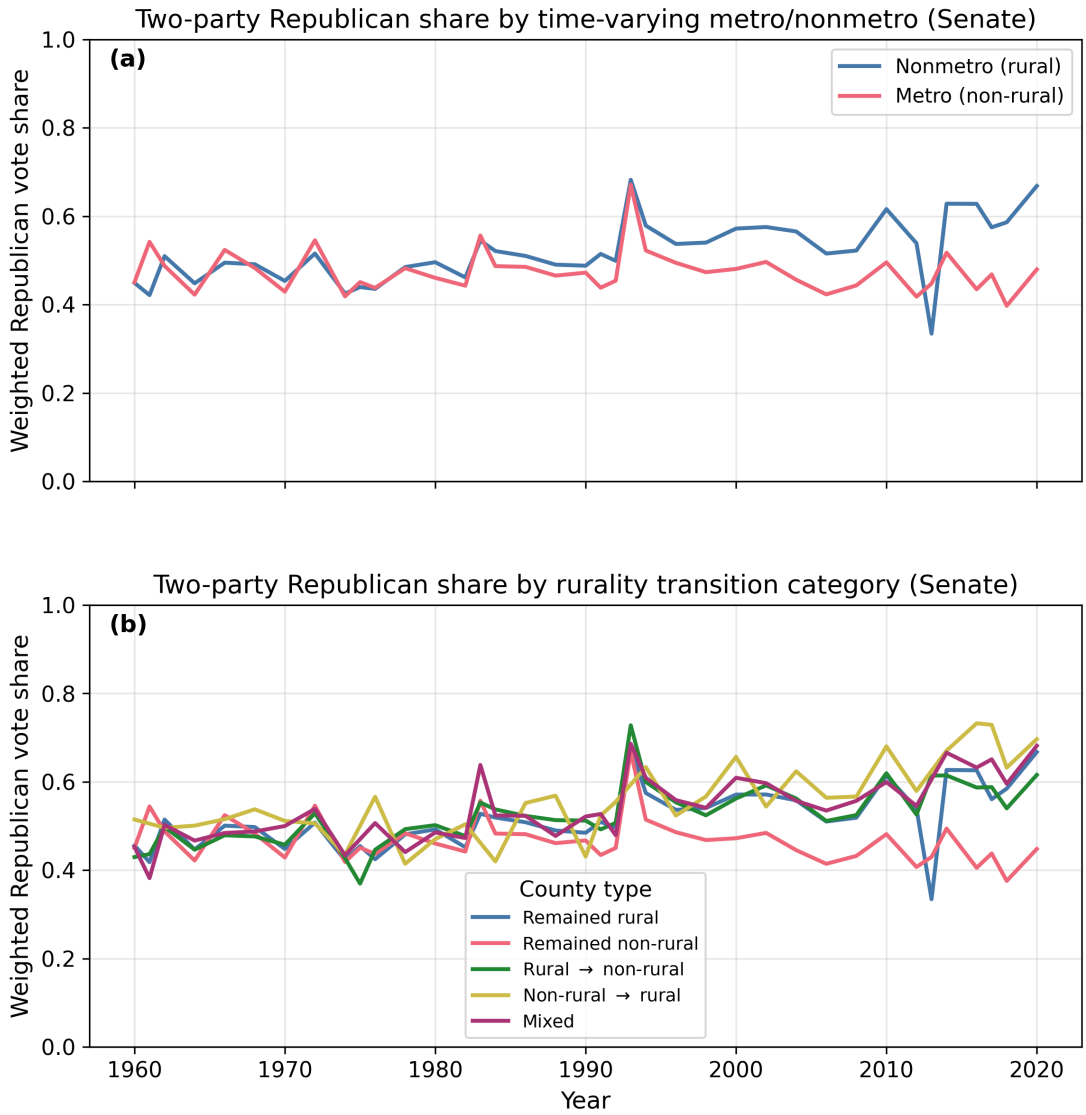

Figure 8: (a) Senate Republican share by time-varying metro/nonmetro. (b) Senate: means by transition category.

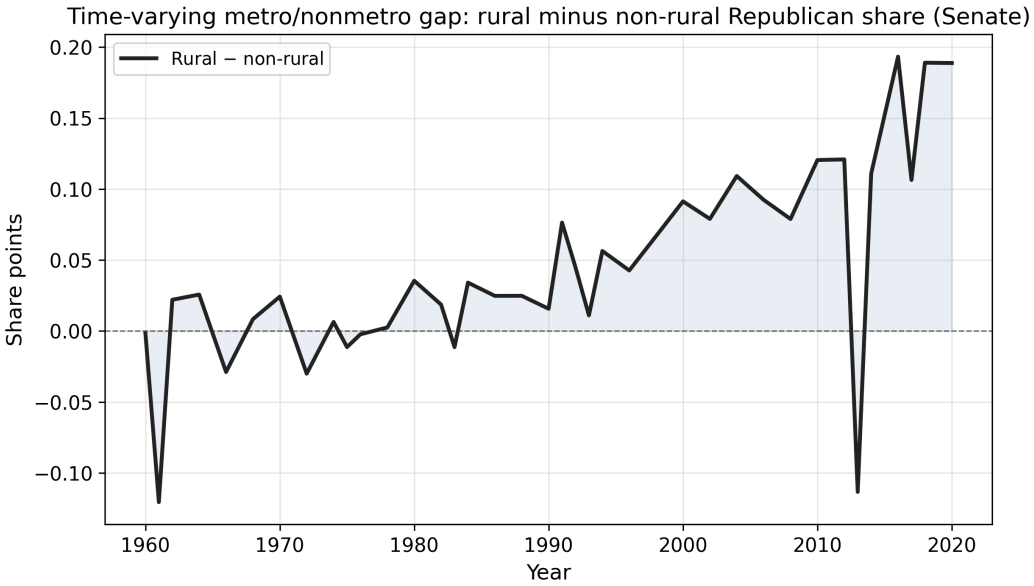

Figure 9: Senate: rural minus non-rural gap.

Table 8: Decomposition of change in rural—non-rural gap (Senate; same construction as presidential)

Office	Spec.	Start	End	N	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Senate	Main	1960	2020	2,358	0.201	-0.003	-0.071	0.276
Senate	Post-1974	1974	2020	1,404	0.173	-0.019	-0.048	0.240

Notes: All entries are share points. Composition holds terminal vote weights and outcomes fixed; see text. Post-1974 uses years ≥ 1974; Senate election years in the merged panel.

Table 9: Decomposition (Senate; time-varying metro/nonmetro RUCC)

Office	Spec.	Start	End	N	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Senate	Main	1960	2020	2,358	0.201	-0.003	-0.071	0.276
Senate	Post-1974	1974	2020	1,404	0.173	-0.019	-0.048	0.240

Notes: Rural status is the **year-specific** RUCC-based indicator (RUCC ≥ 4); the decomposition contrasts rural vs. non-rural vote-weighted means at each endpoint. Units: share points.

Table 10: Decomposition by election span (Senate, main sample)

Office	Period	N	Δ Gap	Comp.	Wt. shift	Within y
Senate	1960–1968	1,326	-0.018	0.000	-0.012	-0.006
Senate	1972–1980	1,247	0.032	0.000	-0.019	0.052
Senate	1980–1992	2,167	-0.001	-0.005	-0.005	0.009
Senate	1992–2000	1,093	0.039	-0.007	-0.009	0.055
Senate	2000–2008	1,318	0.022	0.000	-0.005	0.027
Senate	2008–2016	1,233	0.069	-0.013	0.004	0.078
Senate	2016–2020	1,406	0.052	0.000	-0.001	0.053

Notes: Same construction as presidential; Senate uses Senate election years in the merged panel. Units: share points.

Table 11: WLS category effects by decade bucket (Senate)

	Pre-1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020
Remained rural (intercept)	0.4708*** (0.0161)	0.4946*** (0.0151)	0.5263*** (0.0139)	0.5457*** (0.0175)	0.5975*** (0.0162)	0.6675*** (0.0192)
Remained non-rural (vs. rem. rural)	-0.0098 (0.0136)	-0.0300** (0.0141)	-0.0496*** (0.0140)	-0.0976*** (0.0185)	-0.1751*** (0.0224)	-0.2194*** (0.0197)
Rural to non-rural (vs. rem. rural)	-0.0028 (0.0104)	0.0173* (0.0094)	0.0119 (0.0098)	0.0036 (0.0099)	-0.0225* (0.0130)	-0.0518*** (0.0136)
Non-rural to rural (vs. rem. rural)	0.0361* (0.0191)	0.0192 (0.0244)	0.0297 (0.0218)	0.0588* (0.0349)	0.0602** (0.0283)	0.0292 (0.0482)
Mixed (vs. rem. rural)	0.0123 (0.0219)	0.0013 (0.0192)	0.0168 (0.0153)	0.0245 (0.0192)	0.0065 (0.0238)	0.0142 (0.0243)

Notes: Each column is a **separate** WLS fit on county–years in that decade bucket only; specification is rep_share on transition-category dummies with *remained rural* omitted. Weights: two-party votes; standard errors clustered by state. Coefficients on categories are gaps vs. remained rural in that decade (share units). Intercept row is the fitted level for remained rural. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Table 12: Weighted least squares: Republican share on year and rurality categories (Senate)

	Coef.	SE
Intercept	0.5231***	(0.0100)
Rural to non-rural	-0.0009	(0.0071)
Non-rural to rural	0.0383**	(0.0152)
Mixed	0.0118	(0.0119)
Remained non-rural	-0.0674***	(0.0111)
Year (centered)	0.0028***	(0.0005)
Year (centered) x Rural to non-rural	-0.0005	(0.0003)
Year (centered) x Non-rural to rural	0.0006	(0.0009)
Year (centered) x Mixed	0.0002	(0.0008)
Year (centered) x Remained non-rural	-0.0036***	(0.0005)

Notes: WLS weights are two-party votes. Standard errors clustered by state. Omitted category: remained rural. $N = 67,491$, states=49, $R^2 = 0.081$. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Table 13: Weighted least squares: time-varying rural vs. non-rural (Senate)

	Coef.	SE
Intercept	0.5236***	(0.0095)
Year (centered)	0.0027***	(0.0005)
Non-rural (vs. rural)	-0.0605***	(0.0105)
Year (centered) x Non-rural	-0.0031***	(0.0005)

Notes: WLS weights are two-party votes. Standard errors clustered by state. **Rural** (time-varying RUCC, RUCC ≥ 4) is the **omitted** category; coefficients describe **non-rural** relative to rural in the same county–year. $N = 67,491$, states=49, $R^2 = 0.048$. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Table 14: Senate: baseline gaps (1960–1988) and change in gap vs. that baseline by election (*remained rural* omitted). $N = 67,491$, states=49, $R^2 = 0.112$.

Category	1960–1988 gap	1990	1991	1992	1993	1994	1996	1998	2000	2002	2004	2006	2008	2010	2012	2013	2014	2016	2017	2018	2020
Remained non-rural	-0.0171 (0.0127)	-0.0002 (0.0219)	-0.0577** (0.0127)	-0.0294 (0.0191)	0.0078 (0.0127)	-0.0432* (0.0222)	-0.0135** (0.0161)	-0.0554** (0.0217)	-0.0817*** (0.0259)	-0.0598** (0.0248)	-0.0956*** (0.0257)	-0.0786*** (0.0261)	-0.0049** (0.0203)	-0.1152*** (0.0222)	-0.1149*** (0.0230)	0.1128*** (0.0178)	-0.1156*** (0.0191)	-0.2035*** (0.0448)	-0.1057*** (0.0127)	-0.1917*** (0.0269)	-0.2022*** (0.0232)
Rural to non-rural	0.0070 (0.0090)	0.0206 (0.0205)	-0.0238*** (0.0090)	0.0031 (0.0181)	0.0429*** (0.0090)	0.0180 (0.0201)	0.0101 (0.0110)	-0.0234 (0.0158)	-0.0159 (0.0166)	0.0136 (0.0192)	-0.0020 (0.0161)	-0.0057 (0.0184)	-0.0010 (0.0156)	-0.0016 (0.0181)	-0.0204 (0.0172)	0.2727*** (0.0203)	-0.0193 (0.0175)	-0.0469** (0.0187)	0.0204** (0.0090)	-0.0517** (0.0216)	-0.0598*** (0.0165)
Non-rural to rural	0.0200* (0.0180)	-0.0820 (0.0635)	-0.0156 (0.0180)	0.0279 (0.0228)	0.0000*** (0.0000)	0.0286 (0.0263)	-0.0428 (0.0320)	-0.0038 (0.0316)	0.0554 (0.0383)	-0.0574 (0.0644)	0.0357 (0.0588)	0.0238 (0.0572)	0.0177 (0.0894)	0.0361 (0.0320)	0.0108 (0.0439)	-0.0000*** (0.0000)	0.0127 (0.0923)	0.0703** (0.0357)	0.1361** (0.0180)	0.0175 (0.0385)	-0.0008 (0.0550)
Mixed	0.0087 (0.0185)	0.0282 (0.0289)	0.0092 (0.0185)	-0.0264 (0.0218)	-0.0005 (0.0185)	0.0258 (0.0241)	0.0134 (0.0231)	-0.0063 (0.0249)	0.0294 (0.0289)	0.0170 (0.0353)	-0.0098 (0.0389)	0.0161 (0.0340)	0.0295 (0.0384)	-0.0231 (0.0411)	-0.0025 (0.0323)	0.0000** (0.0000)	0.0303 (0.0384)	-0.0025 (0.0426)	0.0816** (0.0185)	0.0022 (0.0336)	0.0056 (0.0333)

Notes: Vote-weighted WLS; SEs clustered by state. **1960–1988 gap** is the category coefficient in the baseline period (vs. *remained rural*). Later columns are **interaction** terms: change in that gap relative to 1960–1988 for the listed election. Share units (0–1). $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Table 15: Senate: time-varying rural (omitted) vs. non-rural; 1960–1988 baseline and post-1988 election interactions. $N = 67,491$, states=49, $R^2 = 0.079$.

Row	1960–1988 base	1990	1991	1992	1993	1994	1996	1998	2000	2002	2004	2006	2008	2010	2012	2013	2014	2016	2017	2018	2020
Rural (level / Δ vs. 1960–1988)	0.4804*** (0.0135)	0.0077 (0.0023)	0.0343** (0.0135)	0.0187 (0.0169)	0.2021*** (0.0135)	0.0885*** (0.0191)	0.0569*** (0.0184)	0.0680*** (0.0221)	0.0917*** (0.0255)	0.0952*** (0.0296)	0.0852*** (0.0265)	0.0352 (0.0318)	0.0420 (0.0387)	0.1357*** (0.0246)	0.0585** (0.0291)	−0.1469*** (0.0135)	0.1489*** (0.0277)	0.1477*** (0.0256)	0.0945*** (0.0135)	0.1066*** (0.0252)	0.1861*** (0.0258)
Non-rural (vs. rural)	−0.0347 (0.0117)	0.0010 (0.0185)	−0.0595*** (0.0117)	−0.0282* (0.0163)	0.0056 (0.0117)	−0.0385*** (0.0197)	−0.0260* (0.0141)	−0.0502** (0.0195)	−0.0747*** (0.0228)	−0.0622** (0.0317)	−0.0955*** (0.0232)	−0.0758*** (0.0226)	−0.0622** (0.0177)	−0.1038*** (0.0197)	−0.1042*** (0.0199)	0.1309*** (0.0120)	−0.0842*** (0.0182)	−0.1766*** (0.0416)	−0.0998*** (0.0117)	−0.1723*** (0.0251)	−0.1721*** (0.0206)

Notes: Vote-weighted WLS; SEs clustered by state. **Rural** is the RUCC-based indicator in each county–year (RUCC ≥ 4); **rural** is omitted. **1960–1988 base:** rural row = intercept (fitted Republican share for rural county–years in the baseline period); non-rural row = non-rural minus rural in that baseline. **Later columns** on the rural row are **period mains** (change in rural fitted level vs. the baseline block at each election). On the non-rural row they are **interactions**: change in the non-rural minus rural gap relative to 1960–1988. Share units (0–1). $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

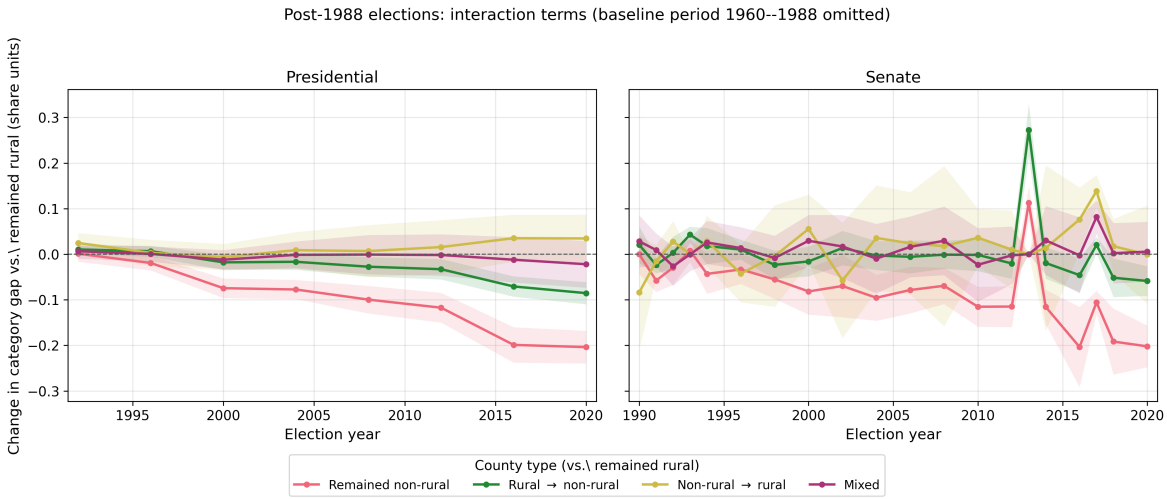

Figure 10: Post-1988 election × category interactions (presidential and Senate panels).

7 Appendix B: Unweighted county–year OLS (robustness)

The main specification weights county–years by two-party vote totals (voting-population estimand). The table below repeats the same transition-category specification with unweighted OLS (equal weight per county–year) alongside WLS, for both offices, with state-clustered standard errors.

Replication

From the repository root (after dependencies in `requirements.txt`):

1. `python3 scripts/data_manager_20251025.py`
2. `python3 scripts/analysis_20251025.py`
3. `python3 scripts/kitagawa_gap_decomposition_20251025.py`
4. `python3 scripts/compare_tv_vs_baseline_rural_gap_20251025.py`
5. `python3 scripts/build_empirical_report_assets_20251025.py`
6. `quarto render docs/manuscript/paper.qmd` (requires Quarto; install via Homebrew `brew install quarto`, Conda `conda install -c conda-forge quarto`, or the official installer—see `docs/manuscript/QUARTO.md` in this repository).

The manuscript is the primary narrative document. A technical companion with supplementary tables, diagnostics, and appendix-style summaries is `docs/reports/empirical_methods_and_results.qmd`.

Table 16: Robustness: vote-weighted WLS vs. unweighted OLS (same specification; SEs clustered by state)

	Presidential				Senate			
	WLS		OLS		WLS		OLS	
	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE
Intercept	0.5654***	(0.0065)	0.5813***	(0.0100)	0.5231***	(0.0100)	0.5275***	(0.0160)
Rural to non-rural	-0.0002	(0.0066)	-0.0117	(0.0077)	-0.0009	(0.0071)	-0.0191*	(0.0097)
Non-rural to rural	0.0433***	(0.0132)	0.0318**	(0.0153)	0.0383**	(0.0152)	0.0328*	(0.0196)
Mixed	0.0135	(0.0100)	0.0003	(0.0103)	0.0118	(0.0119)	-0.0095	(0.0119)
Remained non-rural	-0.0880***	(0.0107)	-0.0488***	(0.0120)	-0.0674***	(0.0111)	-0.0430***	(0.0135)
Year (centered)	0.0020***	(0.0003)	0.0026***	(0.0004)	0.0028***	(0.0005)	0.0040***	(0.0006)
Year (centered) x Rural to non-rural	-0.0010***	(0.0003)	-0.0006**	(0.0002)	-0.0005	(0.0003)	0.0004	(0.0004)
Year (centered) x Non-rural to rural	0.0006	(0.0006)	-0.0003	(0.0005)	0.0006	(0.0009)	-0.0000	(0.0010)
Year (centered) x Mixed	-0.0001	(0.0005)	0.0002	(0.0005)	0.0002	(0.0008)	0.0012*	(0.0007)
Year (centered) x Remained non-rural	-0.0034***	(0.0004)	-0.0026***	(0.0003)	-0.0036***	(0.0005)	-0.0019***	(0.0005)

Notes: WLS uses two-party votes as weights; OLS gives equal weight to each county–year. Same formula as Table 3; standard errors clustered by state. Presidential WLS: $N = 49,783$, OLS: $N = 49,783$. Senate WLS: $N = 67,491$, OLS: $N = 67,491$.

Data appendix

7.1 Rural and non-rural coding (data appendix)

Author: Jason Fletcher, University of Wisconsin–Madison

This appendix documents how **rural** is defined in the raw USDA materials, how it enters the merged election panel, how **early years** are filled, how **time-invariant transition categories** are built, and how **missing matches** are handled. The merged analysis file and construction script are listed in the manuscript's Replication section.

7.1.1 Source: USDA Rural–Urban Continuum Codes (RUCC)

The primary source file in this repository is:

`data_raw/county_year_rucc_1970_2024.csv`

Each row is intended to represent a **county** (`county_fips`) in a **reference year** (`year`), with:

Column (typical)	Role
`county_fips`	5-digit FIPS (stored in raw as numeric; harmonised to zero-padded strings in code)
`year`	Year the row applies to (panel year)
`snapshot_year`	USDA vintage used to assign codes (e.g. 1974, 1983, …) when applicable
`rucc_code`	RUCC value on the USDA 1–9 scale
`rural_flag`	**Boolean** used in merges: derived in the raw extract such that **non-metropolitan** counties are rural

7.1.1.1 Metro vs. non-metro threshold (project rule)

Following standard USDA usage for this project:

- **Rural (`rural_flag == True`):** county is **non-metropolitan** under RUCC (conventionally **RUCC 4** on the 1–9 scale: nonmetro categories).
- **Non-rural (`rural_flag == False`): metropolitan** (RUCC 1–3).

The pipeline **does not recompute** `rural_flag` from `rucc_code` in `data_manager_20251025.py`; it **trusts** the boolean in the CSV after coercion (see below). If you replace the raw RUCC file, ensure `rural_flag` matches your chosen threshold or add an explicit `rucc_code → rural` step in code.

7.1.1.2 Time-varying rural status

For each **county–year** in the merged file, `rural_flag` reflects the **RUCC-based** metro/non-metro classification for **that year** after harmonisation. It is **not** fixed across decades: a county can move from rural to non-rural (or the reverse) when USDA snapshots change and the panel is updated.

7.1.2 From raw RUCC to the merged panel

7.1.2.1 FIPS harmonisation

- Election and RUCC FIPS are coerced to **5-character strings** (e.g. `01001`). Invalid values become missing and election rows with missing FIPS are dropped before merge.

7.1.2.2 Boolean coercion of `rural_flag`

In `load_rucc()`, the raw `rural_flag` is mapped to **True** if:

- string forms `"true"`, `"1"`, `"t"` (case-insensitive), or
- numeric value present and $> \mathbf{0}$.

Otherwise it is **False** (including missing/zero/negative indicators in the raw file).

7.1.2.3 Merge with elections

Election county–years are **left-merged** to the RUCC panel on **`(county_fips, year)`**. If there is **no** RUCC row for that pair, `rural_flag` (and other RUCC-side fields) are missing on the merged row.

7.1.3 Synthetic years before the first observed RUCC year

Raw county-level RUCC often **starts in 1970** (or later for some counties). Without adjustment, election years **1960–1969** would not match any RUCC row.

Procedure: For each county, let (Y_0) be the **minimum** `year` in the RUCC file for that `county_fips`. If (Y_0 > 1960), the script **creates** synthetic rows for years **1960, ..., (Y_0 - 1)** with `rural_flag` equal to that county's classification **at year (Y_0)** (earliest observed snapshot).

Interpretation: Pre-(Y_0) years use a **constant carry-back** of the first available USDA classification. This is a **measurement assumption**, not a claim that metro status was unchanged in reality. Sensitivity analyses (e.g. restricting to **year 1970** or **1974**) are appropriate for conclusions that depend heavily on the 1960s.

7.1.4 Time-invariant transition categories (`rural_category`)

Separate from **year-specific** `rural_flag`, each county is assigned one **transition category** based on the **path** of `rural_flag` over **1960–2020** on the **expanded** RUCC panel (including synthetic early years):

Code	Meaning
`remained_rural`	Rural in **every** observed year in range
`remained_nonrural`	Non-rural in **every** observed year
`changed_to_nonrural`	Starts rural, ends non-rural (with only those two states along a monotone path in the implementation)
`changed_to_rural`	Starts non-rural, ends rural
`mixed`	Both rural and non-rural appear but the path does not fit the simple start/end pattern above

Implementation detail: logic uses **first** and **last** year in range per county and whether the county **ever** appears fully rural or fully non-rural; irregular paths are labelled **`mixed`**.

These categories are **fixed** for a county: they summarise long-run reclassification, not the current year's status.

7.1.5 Listwise deletion of unmatched county–years (Option A)

After the merge, any row with **missing `rural_flag`** still has **no** RUCC match even after synthetic back-fill (e.g. **historical FIPS** that never appear in the USDA file—defunct Virginia geographies, Ormsby County NV, Washabaugh SD, etc.).

Policy: Those rows are **dropped** before writing `county_year_voting_merged.csv`:

```
merged = merged.dropna(subset=["rural_flag"])
```

The number dropped in each build is reported in **`docs/data_issues_report.md`**. The share is **tiny** relative to the full panel; national statistics are essentially unchanged, but the panel is **complete** on rural coding for all retained rows.

For crosswalk-based recovery of defunct FIPS (Option B in `docs/rural_measurement_missingness_options.md`), see that memo; it is **not** implemented in the default pipeline.

7.1.6 Variables in the merged file (rurality-related)

Variable	Type	Description
`rural_flag`	Boolean	Time-varying rural (non-metro) vs non-rural (metro)
`rural_category`	String	One of five transition categories (see above)

The merged file does **not** retain `rucc_code` or `snapshot_year` unless you extend `data_manager_20251025.py` to pass them through from the raw CSV.

7.1.7 Relation to published reports

Empirical reports in this repository (**presidential and Senate only** for national gaps and decompositions) use this coding. **Gubernatorial** rows remain in the merged file for other uses but are excluded from those report tables and figures by convention.

7.1.8 Replication

Rebuild the panel and issue summary:

```
python3 scripts/data_manager_20251025.py
```

Then refresh downstream tables and figures (analysis, Kitagawa, comparison scripts, report assets) as in `docs/reports/empirical_methods_and_results.qmd`.

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Kitagawa, Evelyn M. 1955. "Components of a Difference Between Two Rates." *Journal of the American Statistical Association* 50 (272): 1168–94. https://doi.org/10.1080/01621459.1955.10501231.

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